YOUR CAREER HAS NO PATCH TUESDAY

Career Vulnerability Assessment

Fifteen controls. Check what's true today. Score yourself before someone else scores you.

FINANCIAL RUNWAY — *your backup strategy*

- [ ] I know my real monthly burn (expenses, not salary) and have 6+ months banked.
- [ ] I have run a trial month on my "laid-off budget" — the backup is tested.
- [ ] My plan does not depend on severance I have not received.

NETWORK — *you can't build a SOC during the incident*

- [ ] I invest in my professional community while employed (chapters, mentoring, intros).
- [ ] I have made more deposits than withdrawals — people I've helped outnumber favors I've asked.
- [ ] For each company on my someday-list, I know at least one human inside it.

PORTFOLIO — *assets your employer doesn't own*

- [ ] I have public work under my own name: a talk, article, podcast, or teaching credit this year.
- [ ] I own artifacts (templates, runbooks, frameworks) that travel with me, not my badge.
- [ ] If my employer's brand vanished tomorrow, my expertise would still be findable online.

MARKET READINESS — *the warm-standby resume*

- [ ] My resume was updated in the last quarter, with quantified accomplishments.
- [ ] I keep a brag file — wins, metrics, kudos — captured the week they happen.
- [ ] I know my current market rate because I talk to recruiters even when I'm happy.

DETECTION — *career indicators of compromise*

- [ ] I track org-level signals: reorgs, leadership churn, budget and hiring freezes.
- [ ] I would notice if my function began centralizing, offshoring, or being planned without me.
- [ ] I have decided in advance what signal level triggers my active preparation.

SCORING

13–15: Resilient — maintain the controls. **9–12: Exposed** — patch the weakest domain this month.
0–8: Critical — you are the unpatched system. Start with runway and resume; they take the longest.

James R. McQuiggan, CISSP | Apparent Security — Making Cyber Threats Apparent
jamesmcquiggan.com · cal.com/jamesrmcquiggan · Not legal or financial advice — consult professionals for your situation.

YOUR CAREER HAS NO PATCH TUESDAY

The First 72-Hour Runbook

When the incident is real: contain first, respond second. Work the phases in order.

HOURS 0–24 CONTAIN

- Don't sign anything — in the room or online. **Lawyer up.** Severance agreements have review periods — use them.
- Get everything in writing: severance, PTO payout, equity treatment, benefits end-date.
- Solve health coverage deliberately: COBRA vs. marketplace vs. spouse's plan — do the math.
- File for unemployment the same day. No shame; you funded it.
- Freeze discretionary spending until the runway math is done.
- Tell your family today. Carrying it alone compounds the damage.

HOURS 24–48 CONTROL THE NARRATIVE

- Draft your disclosure post: gratitude for the run + clarity about what happened + a specific ask.
- Publish within ~48 hours — you set the story or the silence does. Bitterness is a self-inflicted reference check.
- Activate "Open to Work" deliberately. It is a signal flare, not a stigma.
- Run the runway math: months of expenses banked ÷ real monthly burn = your decision clock.
- Process the emotions on purpose: don't let it fester, don't suppress it. It is a grief event.

HOURS 48–72 STAND UP THE SYSTEM

- Adopt the operating principle: "My job is getting a new job." Set hours. Get dressed. Work the pipeline.
- Build the tracker: target companies, applications, contacts, follow-ups, weekly review.
- Write the target list, then apply on company sites (job boards for discovery only — kills fake postings).
- Identify one internal advocate per target company. Referrals beat portals.
- Commit to the cadence: one cash-flow action daily, one future-building action weekly.



Contain first. Respond second.

There is no Patch Tuesday coming for your career.

The patch is you. The maintenance window is now.

James R. McQuiggan, CISSP | Apparent Security — Making Cyber Threats Apparent
jamesmcquiggan.com · cal.com/jamesrmcquiggan · Not legal or financial advice — consult professionals for your situation.